# Mark Scheme (Results)

# History

**Paper 3: Modern depth study**

**Option 31: Weimar and Nazi Germany, 1918-39**

## Mock Paper 1 (NotebookLM Prediction) - Teacher Copy

## SECTION A

**Answer ALL questions in this section.**

**1** Give two things you can infer from Source A about the new Weimar Constitution. (4)

* **(i) What I can infer:** I can infer that the Weimar Constitution faced significant internal political hostility from conservative elements from its very inception.

* *Details in the source that tell me this:* The source states that the author listened to debates with "real concern, looking at the gentlemen of the Right" who believed the nation "resists it with every sinew in its body".

* **(ii) What I can infer:** I can infer that the German public was culturally unaccustomed to democratic governance and preferred authoritarian rule.

* *Details in the source that tell me this:* The source states that "Germans cannot shake off their old political timidity and their submissive deference to the authoritarian state".

**2** **Explain why the Weimar Republic faced significant political instability in the years 1919–23.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- The Treaty of Versailles
- The Kapp Putsch

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

The Weimar Republic was born out of defeat in the First World War, which immediately triggered severe political instability between 1919 and 1923. One primary cause of this instability was the widespread anger and resentment surrounding the Treaty of Versailles. Signed reluctantly by the new Social Democratic government in June 1919, the treaty was near-universally condemned in Germany as a *Diktat*—a dictated peace imposed without negotiation. In particular, Article 231 (the "War Guilt" clause) forced Germany to accept sole responsibility for the war, which deeply humiliated the population and fostered the *Dolchstosslegende* (the "stab-in-the-back" myth). This myth claimed that the German army had not been defeated militarily but was betrayed from within by the socialist politicians who signed the Armistice—dubbed the "November Criminals". Consequently, this severely undermined the legitimacy of the Weimar democracy and made its political leaders permanent targets for right-wing nationalists.

Furthermore, this extreme polarization of German politics led to direct physical challenges to the state from both the Left and the Right. When the government attempted to reduce the size of the army and disband the Freikorps (nationalist paramilitary units of ex-soldiers) to meet the military restrictions of Versailles, right-wing military figures revolted. Led by Wolfgang Kapp and backed by armed Freikorps troops, they successfully seized Berlin in March 1920. The weakness of the state was highlighted when the regular army (*Reichswehr*) refused to fire on the rebels. The Weimar politicians were forced to flee Berlin, and the putsch was only defeated because the government called for a general strike of trade unions and civil servants, which paralyzed the city's infrastructure. This proved that the government lacked a reliable monopoly on physical force and depended on extra-parliamentary measures to survive.

Finally, this political instability was exacerbated by a targeted campaign of right-wing terrorism and political assassinations. Between 1919 and 1922, right-wing extremists carried out 376 political murders, aimed at eliminating democratic politicians and destabilizing the state. The most high-profile victims included Matthias Erzberger, the Centre Party politician who had signed the 1918 Armistice, assassinated in 1921; and Walther Rathenau, the brilliant Weimar Foreign Minister, murdered in 1922. These assassinations, combined with the subsequent hyperinflation crisis of 1923, meant that by the end of 1923, the Weimar Republic's authority was fragile, contested by extremist paramilitary groups, and deeply unpopular among a population that blamed democracy for their national humiliation and economic misery.

**3** **Explain why the German economy recovered in the years 1924–29.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- Gustav Stresemann
- The Rentenmark

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

Following the catastrophic hyperinflation crisis of 1923, the Weimar Republic underwent a dramatic economic recovery during the "Golden Years" of 1924 to 1929. The foremost catalyst for this stabilization was the decisive leadership of Gustav Stresemann, who became Chancellor in August 1923 and subsequently served as Foreign Minister. Stresemann understood that economic recovery required the immediate resolution of hyperinflation and the end of passive resistance in the occupied Ruhr. His first major step in November 1923 was the introduction of a temporary currency, the Rentenmark. Unlike the old paper mark, which had been completely ruined by over-printing, the Rentenmark's value was strictly tied to German property, specifically industrial and agricultural land. This successfully restored public trust. Consequently, in August 1924, this temporary measure was replaced by a permanent, gold-backed currency, the Reichsmark. This decisive monetary reform halted hyperinflation, stabilized prices, and laid the essential groundwork for wider industrial and commercial investment.

A second crucial factor in the recovery was the restructuring of Germany's international obligations through the Dawes Plan of 1924. Under the original terms of the Treaty of Versailles, Germany had been faced with an unpayable reparations bill of £6.6 billion, which had triggered the French invasion of the Ruhr in 1923 when Germany defaulted. The Dawes Plan, negotiated by Stresemann, temporarily reduced Germany's annual payments to a manageable level. Crucially, the plan also provided a massive 800 million gold mark loan from the United States to stimulate the German economy. As a result of these US loans, German factories were rebuilt using modern mechanisation and assembly-line techniques, which dramatically boosted industrial production. Employment increased, and because workers received higher wages, they spent more money in the domestic economy, creating a positive multiplier effect. This economic stability was further secured by the withdrawal of French troops from the Ruhr by 1925, which allowed German coal and steel production to resume without foreign disruption.

Finally, the recovery was supported by Stresemann's foreign policy successes, which restored Germany's international standing and attracted further foreign capital. By signing the Locarno Pact in 1925, Germany accepted its western borders with France and Belgium, which reassured foreign investors of geopolitical stability. This international reconciliation culminated in Germany joining the League of Nations in 1926 with a permanent seat on its council, restoring national pride and encouraging US financiers to invest even more heavily. In 1929, the Young Plan further reduced the total reparations bill to £2 billion and extended the payment term over 59 years, lowering Germany's long-term financial liabilities. Although this recovery was highly dependent on short-term US loans—making it, as Stresemann warned, like "dancing on a volcano"—the combination of currency reform, Dawes Plan loans, and international diplomacy successfully transformed Germany from a bankrupt pariah state into a thriving industrial economy by 1929.

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**SECTION B**

**For use with Section B, Answer ALL questions.**

Source B: From a secret report written by a local public health official in Saxony, December 1935.

"The implementation of the Law for the Prevention of Hereditarily Diseased Offspring is proceeding smoothly, though we must confront lingering traditional prejudices. In this district, we have processed over eighty applications for compulsory sterilisation this year alone. While some families initially protest out of ignorance, the majority are brought to understand that eliminating hereditary defects is a biological duty to the state. The local courts have been highly cooperative, accepting medical recommendations without delay. However, we require more secure facilities to prevent patients from fleeing before the surgical procedures are completed."

Source C: An official Nazi propaganda poster, published by the Office of Racial Policy in 1938. The German text translates to: "60,000 Reichsmarks is what this person suffering from a hereditary defect costs the People's community during his lifetime. Fellow citizen, that is your money too."



Interpretation 1: From The Nazi State and Society by Dr. Julian Kroll, published in 1998.

"The persecution of minorities and disabled people under the Nazi regime was fundamentally driven by a deeply ingrained biological and racial ideology. From the moment they seized power, the Nazis utilized the legal system and public health networks to implement eugenics policies. The German medical profession was highly complicit, willingly submitting thousands of patients for compulsory sterilisation. The general public largely conformed to these measures because they had been thoroughly indoctrinated by racial hygiene propaganda in schools and media. This pseudoscience convinced ordinary citizens that sterilising the disabled was essential to protect the purity of the Aryan gene pool."

Interpretation 2: From The Economics of Terror by Professor Arthur Kitson, published in 2004.

"While racial rhetoric was always present, the driving force behind the escalating persecution of disabled people was economic utility. During the Great Depression, the Nazi state sought to justify its welfare cuts by portraying the vulnerable as a parasitic financial burden on the hard-working taxpayer. Propaganda deliberately targeted the cost of care to build resentment among workers who were themselves enduring long hours and low wages. Active resistance to these policies was minimal because the police state successfully silenced dissent. However, when the regime transitioned from sterilisation to the secret T4 euthanasia programme, public alarm grew, showing that conformity relied on keeping the ultimate fate of these victims hidden from their families."

**3(a) Answer:**
Source B is highly useful for an enquiry into how Nazi sterilisation policies were implemented on a local, administrative level. The content reveals that the *Law for the Prevention of Hereditarily Diseased Offspring* was enforced systematically, with over eighty compulsory sterilisations in one district alone. It is useful because it highlights the complicity of the legal system, noting that local courts cooperated fully by "accepting medical recommendations without delay". The provenance of the source—being a secret report by a local public health official in December 1935—increases its usefulness, as it represents a candid, internal communication not intended for public consumption. This allows the historian to see the true obstacles faced by officials, such as "traditional prejudices" and the fact that "families initially protest," as well as the dark reality that the state had to use "secure facilities" to prevent patients from escaping. Contextually, we know that the Nazis introduced the Sterilisation Law in July 1933, and by 1939, over 400,000 Germans had been forcibly sterilised, validating the scale of persecution described in the source.

Source C is extremely useful for investigating the propaganda methods used by the Nazi regime to justify the persecution of disabled people. The content shows how the Nazis utilized economic scapegoating, explicitly stating that a disabled person "costs the national community 60,000 Reichsmarks". By contrasting a helpless disabled man with an exhausted, healthy worker, the visual imagery was designed to breed resentment among the working class by claiming "that is your money too". The provenance of this source—an official propaganda poster published by the Office of Racial Policy in 1938—is highly useful because it reveals how the state actively sought to "Nazify" public attitudes towards euthanasia and racial hygiene. It shows a deliberate attempt to prepare the public mind for harsher measures by framing disabled lives purely in terms of financial cost. Contextually, we know that by 1938, Germany was preparing for war, and the state was ruthlessly prioritizing economic efficiency and rearmament, which culminated in the secret T4 Euthanasia Programme in 1939, making this economic propaganda highly representative of the period's priorities.

**3(b) Answer:**
The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that the persecution of disabled people was

primarily driven by biological and racial ideology, which was widely accepted by a thoroughly indoctrinated German public. It stresses that the medical profession and ordinary citizens complied willingly because they believed in the necessity of protecting "the purity of the Aryan gene pool".

On the other hand, Interpretation 2 argues that the persecution was driven by economic pragmatism and utility, with the state portraying the disabled as a financial burden to justify welfare cuts during a time of economic hardship. Furthermore, it emphasizes that public conformity was not due to ideological belief, but was maintained through the fear of the police state and the strict secrecy surrounding the ultimate fate of the victims.

**3(c) Answer:**
One reason the interpretations differ is because the historians have given weight to different contemporary sources. The author of Interpretation 1 has placed more weight on evidence similar to Source B, which focuses on the administrative and pseudo-scientific execution of "biological duty" and the medicalized language of "hereditary defects". This supports the view that the policy was an ideological crusade of racial hygiene.

In contrast, the author of Interpretation 2 has given more weight to sources like Source C, which emphasizes the financial cost of disabled people, framing them as a burden on "taxpayers" and the "national community". This supports the economic interpretation that the Nazis sought to build class-based resentment to justify the elimination of those they deemed economically unproductive.

**3(d) Answer:**
Interpretation 2 presents a compelling argument that the escalation of Nazi persecution of disabled people was heavily rooted in economic utility and financial scapegoating. To a significant extent, this view is convincing. During the Great Depression and the subsequent drive for economic recovery, the Nazi state sought to eliminate any expenditure on those they classified as "unproductive". This is clearly supported by Source C, which framed disabled individuals as a direct tax drain of "60,000 Reichsmarks" on the hard-working "national community". From my own knowledge, this economic rationale was built into the Nazi concept of the *Volksgemeinschaft* (people's community). To qualify for membership, an individual had to be both racially pure and economically productive. The regime actively cut state welfare budgets, and propaganda targeted the costs of keeping asylum patients alive to build resentment among workers who were enduring longer hours and frozen wages under Robert Ley's German Labour Front (DAF). Thus, the economic framing was a highly practical tool to justify the state's abandonment of the vulnerable.

However, Interpretation 2 downplays the fundamental role of biological and racial ideology, which is the primary focus of Interpretation 1. As Interpretation 1 correctly asserts, eugenics and "racial hygiene" were not merely rhetorical covers for economic cuts; they were the absolute core of Nazi ideology. From my own knowledge, the *Law for the Prevention of Hereditarily Diseased Offspring*, passed in July 1933, was drafted directly by Nazi racial theorists who believed in the pseudoscience of controlled breeding. The complicity of the German medical profession, highlighted in Source B, proves that doctors and judges cooperated not out of economic pressure, but because they had been captured by the "biological duty" to purify the Aryan race. This ideological indoctrination was built directly into the school curriculum, where children were taught "Race Studies" and forced to calculate the hereditary costs of disabled people in mathematics textbooks. Therefore, the ideological belief in social Darwinism provided the initial justification and institutional structure for the persecution.

Furthermore, Interpretation 2 is highly accurate in its analysis of the role of the police state and the limits of public conformity. As Kitson notes, active resistance to sterilisation was minimal because dissent was swiftly crushed by the Gestapo. However, when the regime secretly transitioned to the T4 Euthanasia Programme in late 1939—using carbon monoxide gas to systematically murder disabled children and adults—the conformity of the public began to fracture. From my own knowledge, when families realized that their relatives were dying under suspicious circumstances, protests arose, most notably led by Catholic Bishop Clemens August von Galen in 1941. This forced Hitler to temporarily halt the official T4 program, proving that public acceptance relied entirely on keeping the lethal reality of these policies hidden.

In conclusion, while biological ideology (as emphasized in Interpretation 1) provided the pseudo-scientific framework for sterilisation, it was the economic utility argument highlighted in Interpretation 2 that the regime used to build public acceptance. By framing the disabled as a financial burden during a period of national sacrifice, the Nazis successfully turned ordinary citizens against the most vulnerable, before resorting to absolute secrecy when transitioning to mass murder.

**Enquiry: The persecution of disabled people in Nazi Germany in the years 1933–39**

**3(a) How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the persecution of disabled people in Nazi Germany in the years 1933–39? Explain your answer, using Sources B and C and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)**
**3(b) Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the persecution of disabled people in Nazi Germany in the years 1933–39. What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)**
**3(c) Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the persecution of disabled people in Nazi Germany in the years 1933–39. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4)**
**3(d) How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the persecution of disabled people in Nazi Germany in the years 1933–39? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16+4 SPaG)**

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